APA Archival Producers Alliance

WORKING WITH ARCHIVAL PRODUCERS

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ABOUT THIS GUIDE

This guide presents the advantages of collaborating with a skilled archival team, as well as bringing on an archival producer early in the production process. It is designed to help documentary teams work with archival producers in ways that will maximize their benefit to the production. We encourage filmmakers using archival materials in their documentaries to download, use, and share this resource freely.

This guide is organized into three parts:

1. Role of the Archival Producer - outlines the varying responsibilities typically handled by Archival Producers throughout all phases of film production
2. Archival Team Structures for TV and Film - defines the roles of key team members and outlines potential staffing structures
3. Checklists for Hiring and Onboarding Archival Producers - provides essential information to discuss with prospective and newly-hired Archival Producers

The **Archival Producers Alliance** was founded in 2023 as a way for independent archival producers to come together, create community, and develop best practices around their unique role within the film industry.

The APA represents more than 450 archival producers - and counting - from across the US and around the world.

ROLE OF THE ARCHIVAL PRODUCER

An Archival Producer researches, sources, and manages archival material including footage, photographs, audio, text, and ephemera for use in documentary films & series, feature films, museum exhibits, commercials, and more. This process may involve research online as well as on site at various archives, including academic, commercial, and personal collections. Specifics of an Archival Producer's workflow can vary greatly, but always involve professional archival recordkeeping and expertise in using search engines, finding aids, and databases.

Archival Producers, working in concert with a film's director, producer, and editor, are an integral part of the story-telling team. They source unique and often never-before-seen materials that can drive the narrative and aesthetics of a project; work to verify the veracity and accuracy of primary source materials; and organize and manage archival assets to ease the editing and rights & clearances processes.

Archival Producers have deep knowledge of, and close relationships with, a wide range of archives. They also can come to projects with unique expertise about a time period or subject matter. Their experience and relationships help facilitate the research, sourcing, and clearing of archival material. They manage archival budgets and make sure the research, Fair Use checks, and mastering fit into the production schedule.

BENEFITS OF WORKING WITH AN ARCHIVAL PRODUCER OR TEAM

- Inform and guide story development with the appropriate and, sometimes, newly unearthed archive
- Establish overall strategy for media management, asset tracking, and ease of use of archival (e.g. searchability within internal database)
- Draw on their network of archives to find un-digitized media not available online
- Lower overall costs by negotiating favorable licensing deals, exploring more affordable options, optimizing usage to meet order minimums, and implementing a strategic approach to Fair Use
- Anticipate research, clearance, and delivery issues that could impact the production schedules
- Facilitate the clearance process and legal reviews
- Oversee the delivery of high-resolution masters after picture lock

ARCHIVAL PRODUCER DUTIES DURING EACH PHASE OF PRODUCTION

✳ DEVELOPMENT

- Review chronology of the story
- Understand central characters, events, locations, dates, and keywords
- Identify institutional archives and personal collections
- Consult with production team about budget for archival research and licensing
- Consult with production team about schedule and turnaround time for research, rights & clearances, and final delivery

✳ PRE-PRODUCTION

- Determine workflows and systems for asset management and tracking (e.g. Google Sheets, Airtable, Filemaker, etc.) with the production and/or editing team
- Discuss production's Fair Use and/or legal strategy
- Gather vendor rates and licensing information
- Set expectations regarding availability and turnaround times for offline materials (i.e. archival materials that are not accessible online)
- Begin and track research – including for footage, stills, text, ephemera, audio, etc.

✳ PRODUCTION

- Gather screeners and low-resolution materials (i.e. footage, stills, audio, text, ephemera) for offline edit, while identifying copyright holders of that material
- Continue to strategize on rights & clearances approach
- Communicate regularly with production team to track the archival needs of the project
- Identify important content for the director to consider when conducting interviews, reenactments, or recreations
- Identify media that may be problematic (such as clips containing sensitive populations, multiple copyright holders, music, trademarks and logos, etc.)
- Track budget of archival materials being used

✳ POST-PRODUCTION

- Review the film with director/producer, and/or edit team before picture lock to ensure each piece of archival content can be:
  a) available at the resolution needed
  b) affordable
  c) available on time
- Review edit decision lists (EDLs) to create necessary documents for the post-production process and delivery:
  a) logs for Fair Use reviews
  b) status of master orders and clearances
  c) other deliverables to streamers and distributors, including final archival cue sheets

POST-PRODUCTION CONTINUED

- Create interim and final cost reports. Advise on ways to mitigate costs (e.g. meeting archive minimums, replacing costly shots, etc.)
- Advise on Fair Use process and when possible attend Fair Use reviews with production's legal team
- Obtain high-resolution masters and licenses. This includes:
  a) overseeing Legal & Standards review when required by an archive (e.g. when using network talent or other 'premium' material)
  b) concluding cost negotiations
  c) reviewing licensing agreements and noting legal concerns that should be discussed with production counsel
- Track and draft end credits for archival assets
- Report final usage to the licensors, track payments for license fees, and handle any related paperwork

TRACKING EMERGING TECHNOLOGY

- The Archival Producers Alliance considers Generative AI to be its own element that should be treated in a unique way, similar to animation or graphics. We strongly urge productions to determine who on the staff will track and communicate uses of GenAI.
- Production should consult with the Archival Producer any time Generative AI is used to alter an archival element or create an element that could be understood to be an archival element
- Refer to the APA's Best Practices for Use of Generative AI in Documentaries for more information and guidance

ARCHIVAL TEAM STRUCTURES FOR TV AND FILM

ARCHIVAL TEAM STRUCTURE

Different projects require different archival staffing. Projects in the tv and streaming space tend to be on tighter schedules that require producers to engage more than one Archival Producer, or to establish an archival/clearance team to ensure the desired quality while meeting post and delivery deadlines. Feature and short documentaries tend to have production calendars that are very different from the ones in the tv and streaming space. Here there is often a single Archival Producer handling all archival-related aspects of a project. The APA encourages producers to consider support systems for the Archival Producers in this work; be it an Associate (Archival) Producer, a PA, an intern, or an archival researcher.

Roles of an archival team can include:

Supervising (Archival) Producer: Experienced Archival Producer in a supervisory position.

Archival Producer(s): Experienced Archival Producer to oversee archival research and workflow (see above). This position can be considered "above the line," depending on the creative contribution to the final film and how much of the film is archival. This position often includes directing the work of archival researchers.

Associate Archival Producer(s): Assists Archival Producer with a wide range of tasks - such as research, outreach to sources, logging, formatting EDLs, filling out cue sheets, preparing order forms and Exhibit A's for materials releases. Communicates with editor(s) and story producers; helps track changes/new archival needs in the edit.

Clearance Manager/Clearance Coordinator: Assists Archival Producer by communicating with vendors and legal to vet and eventually sign agreements, flagging clearance issues for the team; sends out materials releases for signature; updates final cue sheets with rights and restrictions.

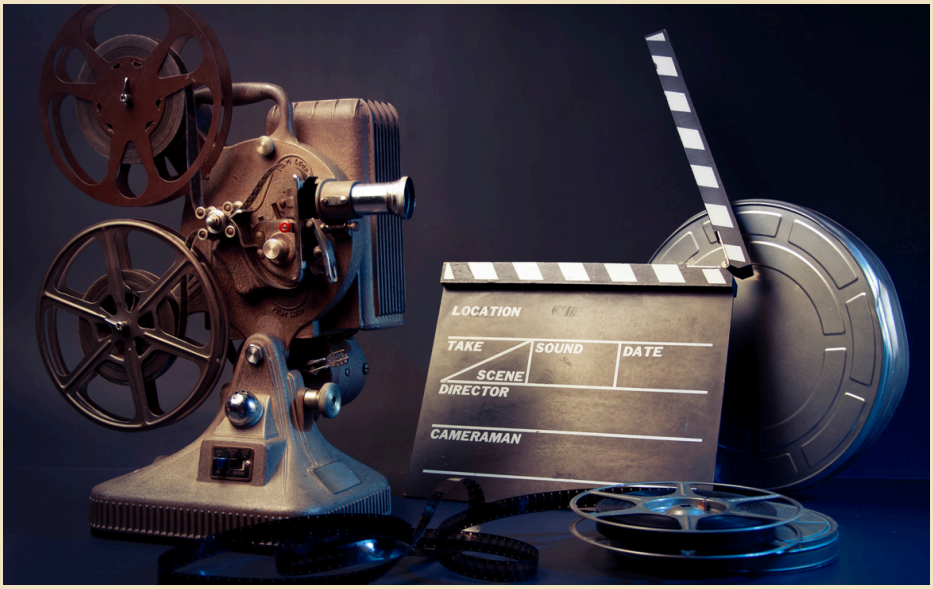
Archival Researcher(s): Supports Archival Producer with additional research (e.g. sourcing archival materials from primary sources online and in person at various archives).

HIRING AND ONBOARDING AN ARCHIVAL PRODUCER

KEY INFORMATION TO SHARE WHEN HIRING AN ARCHIVAL PRODUCER

ABOUT THE PROJECT

- Title and type of project (editorial, educational or commercial / short, feature, series, etc.)
- Specific archival knowledge or expertise that is required (i.e. familiarity with a subject matter, time period, genre, language, etc.)
- Estimated percentage of archival screen time in the final production
- Production schedule and current stage
- Notable partners or talent (e.g. individuals, institutions, estates, NGOs, sports leagues, etc.)



ABOUT THE PRODUCTION COMPANY AND TEAM

- Key creative partners on the project including director, show-runner, line producer, story producer, editor, etc. and who will direct the Archival Producer's work
- Archival support staff (e.g. an Associate Archival Producer, Archival Researcher, etc.)
- Legal counsel, if relevant
- Distributor/broadcaster/end user name, if known

ABOUT THE POSITION

- Archival Producer salary (hourly/daily/weekly rate)
- Start and end date, along with overall production calendar
- Projected total number of days or weeks (billing/payroll - 1099 or W2 - policy on sick days, paid/unpaid time off)
- Expectations for dark days and delays in production process
- Expectations regarding work from home, in-person work, or hybrid
- Anticipated travel for project

KEY INFORMATION TO SHARE WHEN ONBOARDING AN ARCHIVAL PRODUCER

ABOUT THE PROJECT AND TEAM

- Which rights the production needs (e.g. all media, worldwide, in perpetuity)
- Sensitive topics or information
- Expectations with regards to team communication (e.g. production meetings, Slack, etc.)
- Expectations about how creatively involved this role will be, possibly establishing whether the credit will be above the line or below the line
- Programs used to organize materials (spreadsheets, Airtable, etc.)
- Editing software (Avid, Premiere, Final Cut, etc.)

CREATIVE AND LOGISTICAL CONSIDERATIONS

- Existing production materials that will guide and inform research (e.g. outlines, scripts, decks, etc.)
- Schedules for picture lock and archival licensing (e.g. turnaround time for master orders, approvals)
- Need for archival research/clearance during production (e.g. material to be used during shoots and/or recreations; or inform interview questions)
- Existing media naming conventions, tracking systems, archival logs, databases, file storage structures, etc.
- Distribution delivery requirements, if known

FINANCIAL AND LEGAL CONSIDERATIONS

- Archival budget for screeners, digitization of offline materials, and licensing
- Existing archive/vendor partnerships or relationships, and any to be avoided
- Production's relationship with legal counsel, including the process of vetting/approving agreements
- Fair Use vs. licensing strategy and production's risk tolerance
- Need for guild clearances (i.e. DGA, WGA, SAG)
- Whether GenAI elements are being considered, and if so, who on the team is tracking those, and how the APA's guidelines for use of GenAI might be considered

CONTACT

APA Archival Producers Alliance

Visit our website to learn more about us, join our mailing list, become a member, or donate.

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